



SMELLY GAS

The tidal mud is full of microbes that live by breaking down the remains of dead plants and animals. They can survive without air, but they release a gas called hydrogen sulfide, which smells of rotten eggs. The gas bubbles up out of the mud, making the mudflats smell terrible.

MUD PROCESSORS

The microbes in the mudflats feed millions of burrowing worms, while mollusks such as cockles and clams filter the water for food. Other animals like these tiny spire snails creep over the mud surface, nibbling at seaweeds and dead animals washed in by the tide.



HUNGRY VISITORS

The large number of small animals that live in the mudflats attract flocks of shorebirds as well as wildfowl such as ducks and geese. The birds spread out across the mud at low tide, and retreat to the seashore when the tide comes in again. Food buried in the mud can also attract much bigger animals.



▲ GRIZZLY BEAR

In Alaska, grizzly bears dig in the mud of river estuaries at low tide looking for razor clams and other shellfish.